PROJECT TA · INTERNAL — COMMERCIAL IN CONFIDENCE

# Market and Competitor Analysis

On-demand tutoring for UK GCSE & A-level students · 28 August 2026

# Project TA — Market and Competitor Analysis

**Prepared for:** Project TA board and stakeholders **Author:** Ismail Mansur **Date:** 28 August 2026 **Classification:** Internal — commercial in confidence

> **A note on currency.** This is a UK business serving UK students, so every figure in this paper is stated in pounds sterling. Where a source reported in another currency, the figure has been converted at £1 ≈ $1.27 and is marked as approximate. Original figures are available on request.

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## 1. Purpose

This paper sets out the market Project TA proposes to enter, assesses the competitive field, and makes five recommendations that materially change the product as originally conceived. It is intended to support a decision on whether to proceed to a funded pilot.

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## 2. Executive summary

The proposition — a student submits a question and pays for a fixed block of tutoring time; every qualified tutor is notified with the fee, the topic and the duration; the first to accept delivers the session over chat and a shared whiteboard — is not novel. It has been executed at scale, and several well-capitalised attempts have since failed.

That history is instructive rather than disqualifying. Five findings follow.

**Finding 1 — The mechanic is proven.** Snapask reached approximately 3.2 million students and 350,000 tutors across eight Asian markets on precisely this model.

**Finding 2 — The economics, not the mechanic, are what fail.** Yup operated an almost identical product, raised approximately £18.5m, and ceased operations in February 2025. The most frequently cited cause is tutor remuneration of roughly £8 per hour, a rate that cannot retain numerate graduates.

**Finding 3 — The market for answers has been destroyed.** Chegg's market capitalisation fell from approximately £11.6bn in February 2021 to approximately £90m, with a 31% year-on-year subscriber decline and a 45% headcount reduction in October 2025. Any proposition whose value is the answer itself now competes with a free substitute.

**Finding 4 — The defensible product is therefore a verified human who will not simply provide the answer.** This is the single capability a general-purpose AI assistant cannot offer, and the one Chegg lost.

**Finding 5 — In the UK, safeguarding is the barrier to entry and the differentiator.** UK GDPR, the ICO Age Appropriate Design Code and the Online Safety Act 2023 impose substantial obligations on a service that puts adults and children in direct conversation. This is a genuine cost. It is also a barrier that a small competitor cannot trivially replicate, and it is what parents actually purchase.

**Principal commercial risk.** The model as originally conceived charges a flat fee for fifteen minutes of an undergraduate's time, in a market where the answer is available at no cost, to an audience that largely does not control a payment instrument. Sections 8 to 10 address each element of that risk.

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## 3. Market context

| Metric | Figure |
|---|---|
| UK K-12 online tutoring market growth, 2025–2030 | approx. **+£12.6bn**, 17.2% CAGR |
| Global edtech venture funding, 2021 | approx. £4.6bn |
| Global edtech venture funding, 2023 | approx. £560m (−87%) |
| Chegg market capitalisation, February 2021 | approx. £11.6bn |
| Chegg market capitalisation, 2026 | approx. £90m |
| Chegg subscribers, Q1 2025 | 3.2m, −31% YoY; revenue −30% to approx. £95m |

**Interpretation.** UK demand is growing quickly and is well evidenced. The funding environment is not what it was in 2021, so a venture-scale raise on the strength of the concept alone should not be assumed. The business should be structured to reach profitability at small scale before it seeks growth capital.

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## 4. The UK competitive field

### 4.1 Scheduled marketplaces — the incumbent UK model

**Sherpa** is the most directly relevant UK competitor. GCSE and A-level focus, over 350,000 one-to-one lessons delivered, a 4.8-star rating from more than 40,000 parents, lessons from **£20 per hour**, and native iOS and Android applications already shipped. It claims an average improvement of 2.2 grades. Its model is booking-based rather than on-demand, which is where Project TA differs.

**MyTutor** operates the supply model Project TA proposes: over 5,000 undergraduate tutors drawn from 60 leading universities, founded 2013. **DBS checks are mandatory.** Its published safeguarding and online-safety policies are a useful structural reference.

**Tutorful** — UK marketplace, DBS mandatory. **GoStudent** — pan-European, subscription lesson packages, DBS mandatory. **Superprof, First Tutors, TutorExtra** — DBS *recommended but not required*. This is the low-trust segment of the UK market, and the segment against which Project TA's safeguarding position is most persuasive.

**Third Space Learning** is the UK's largest schools-facing online maths tutoring provider, selling flat annual school licences of approximately **£3,900–11,800** depending on school size, with free pilots and multi-school rollouts. It has raised approximately £12.8m. This is the proven UK route should direct-to-consumer acquisition prove difficult.

### 4.2 International precedents in the on-demand category

These are included because they are the only operators to have run Project TA's exact model at scale. Their pricing is converted to sterling for comparison.

**Snapask (Hong Kong)** — the closest proven precedent. A student photographs a question; the platform alerts suitably qualified tutors; the fastest to respond, frequently within five seconds, is assigned the session and opens a one-to-one chat. Reached approximately 3.2m students and 350,000 tutors across Hong Kong, Taiwan, Japan, South Korea, Thailand, Malaysia, Singapore and Indonesia, on approximately £44.7m raised, including a £27.5m round in 2020. Monetised by **subscription**, not by single session. Reported to have ceased active operation around 2022 as pandemic demand reversed.

**Yup (United States)** — on-demand, chat-based, whiteboard-driven maths tutoring for school-age students, with no video. Raised approximately £18.5m across four rounds. **Ceased operations by February 2025.** Tutor pay of approximately £8 per hour is the most commonly cited cause.

**UPchieve (United States)** — free, 24/7, chat and whiteboard, for eligible lower-income secondary students. Tutors are unpaid volunteers; the service is funded by school partnership fees of approximately **£7,900 per school per year**. It validates both the chat-and-whiteboard interface for this exact age group and the institutional funding route.

**Tutor.com** — 24/7 on-demand across multiple subjects with an interactive whiteboard, at approximately **£23–31 per hour**, distributed heavily through institutions and libraries.

**TutorMe (Pearson)** — virtual classroom with whiteboard, text editor, screen share and audio/video, from approximately **£20 per hour**.

**Skooli** — on-demand sessions with video, chat and whiteboard, connecting students within minutes, billed **per minute at approximately £0.65 (about £39 per hour)**, with discounted prepaid packages. The clearest precedent for per-minute billing.

**Varsity Tutors (Nerdy)** — instant tutoring and classes. Commercially notable: students are billed approximately **£51–75 per hour** while tutors earn approximately **£9–16 per hour**, implying a platform take approaching **70%**.

**Wyzant** — tutors set their own rates, typically **£20–47 per hour**, with a flat **25%** platform commission since January 2019.

**Preply** — tutors set rates, typically **£8–31 per hour**, with a tiered commission of approximately **33%** on initial hours with a new student, falling to **18–22%** at volume.

**Tutorpeers** — peer-to-peer tutoring, free to approximately **£20 per 30 minutes**. The closest comparator on price to Project TA's undergraduate supply model.

### 4.3 AI-first products

Photomath, Gauth, Question.AI, Numerade, Brainly, Khanmigo and general-purpose assistants such as ChatGPT are free or near-free, instantaneous, and available without waiting for a human to accept.

**Assessment.** For "what is the answer to question 7", Project TA cannot compete and should not try. For "I have a mock on Thursday, I do not understand why we integrate by parts here, and I have spent forty minutes on it", a person who sat the same specification recently holds a decisive advantage. The product should be positioned exclusively at the second case.

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## 5. Feature comparison

| Feature | Snapask | Yup | UPchieve | Tutor.com | Skooli | MyTutor | Sherpa | Wyzant | Project TA |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Instant match, no booking | ✅ | ✅ | ✅ | ✅ | ✅ | ❌ | ❌ | ❌ | ✅ |
| Text chat session | ✅ | ✅ | ✅ | ✅ | ✅ | ➖ | ➖ | ➖ | ✅ |
| Shared whiteboard | ➖ | ✅ | ✅ | ✅ | ✅ | ✅ | ✅ | ✅ | ✅ |
| Video required | ❌ | ❌ | ❌ | ❌ | ✅ | ✅ | ✅ | ✅ | ❌ (by design) |
| Photograph-a-question intake | ✅ | ✅ | ➖ | ➖ | ➖ | ❌ | ❌ | ❌ | ✅ |
| **Fee disclosed to tutor before acceptance** | ✅ | ➖ | n/a | ❌ | ❌ | ❌ | ❌ | ❌ | ✅ **unique** |
| Pay per short block | ➖ | ❌ | free | ❌ | ✅ | ❌ | ❌ | ❌ | ✅ |
| Subscription or credit option | ✅ | ✅ | ❌ | ✅ | ✅ | ❌ | ❌ | ❌ | ✅ |
| Undergraduate supply model | ✅ | ➖ | ✅ | ❌ | ❌ | ✅ | ➖ | ➖ | ✅ |
| Mandatory DBS | n/a | n/a | US | US | US | ✅ | ✅ | ❌ | ✅ |
| Transcript retained for safeguarding | ➖ | ➖ | ✅ | ✅ | ➖ | ✅ | ✅ | ❌ | ✅ |
| Exam-board-specific routing | ❌ | ❌ | ❌ | ❌ | ❌ | ❌ | ❌ | ❌ | ✅ **unique** |
| Parent visibility of sessions | ❌ | ➖ | ❌ | ➖ | ➖ | ✅ | ✅ | ➖ | ✅ |

✅ present ➖ partial or undisclosed ❌ absent

## 6. Pricing and platform economics

| Platform | Student pays | Tutor receives | Platform take |
|---|---|---|---|
| Varsity Tutors | £51–75/hr | £9–16/hr | **approx. 70%** |
| Preply | tutor-set, £8–31/hr | 67–82% of rate | 18–33%, tiered |
| Wyzant | tutor-set, £20–47/hr | 75% of rate | 25% flat |
| Skooli | approx. £0.65/min (£39/hr) | undisclosed | — |
| Tutor.com | £23–31/hr | approx. £9–12/hr reported | high |
| TutorMe | from £20/hr | undisclosed | — |
| Sherpa (UK) | from £20/hr | undisclosed | — |
| MyTutor (UK) | £25–60/hr | undisclosed | — |
| Tutorpeers | free–£20 per 30 min | — | — |
| Yup (ceased trading) | subscription | **approx. £8/hr** | terminal |
| **Project TA (proposed)** | **£6 per 15 min (£24/hr)** | **£4 per 15 min (£16/hr)** | **33%** |

**Rationale for the proposed position.**

- **£16 per hour to the tutor** exceeds a UK undergraduate's realistic alternative — retail or hospitality at approximately £11–12 per hour — without eliminating platform margin. This directly addresses the failure mode that ended Yup.
- **£6 for fifteen minutes** is an impulse purchase, below the threshold at which a student must seek parental approval, and materially cheaper per hour than every UK comparator identified.
- **A 33% take** sits between Wyzant's flat 25% and Preply's opening 33%. It is defensible and can be published, which no comparator does.
- **Contribution per single session is approximately £1.61** after card processing. Section 9 sets out why this makes credit packs, not single sessions, the commercial basis of the business.

## 7. Recommended points of differentiation

### Tier 1 — defensible

**1. The fee is disclosed to the tutor before acceptance.** No competitor surfaces this in the notification itself. Wyzant, Preply and Varsity Tutors all place the economics behind a booking flow; in Varsity's case because the numbers are unattractive. A notification reading *£4.00 · A-level Maths · Integration by parts · 15 min* is a transparency proposition aimed at the supply side, which is the harder side of this marketplace to secure. It should be the centrepiece of tutor recruitment.

**2. An explicit commitment not to simply provide the answer.** The substitute product provides answers instantly and free. The commitment should be enforced in the product rather than asserted in marketing: a distinct rating dimension for whether the student understood the material, weighted in the order in which tutors receive questions.

**3. Safeguarding presented as a product feature.** The NSPCC, the National Education Union, the Tutors' Association and the Children's Commissioner for England have each called for mandatory DBS checks for private tutors, the latter describing it as "an absolute basic minimum". Several UK platforms still treat checks as optional. A public commitment to universal DBS checks, retained and parent-accessible transcripts, and a prohibition on the exchange of contact details places Project TA on the correct side of an emerging regulatory and reputational shift.

**4. Text-first, camera-off delivery.** Competitors at the premium end require video. For a fifteen-year-old who is embarrassed not to understand something, not being required to appear on camera is a material benefit. It also removes WebRTC infrastructure cost and makes safeguarding review straightforward, because text is searchable and video is not.

**5. Exam-board-specific routing.** AQA, Edexcel, OCR and WJEC/Eduqas differ materially. No on-demand platform routes on examination board. The feature is inexpensive to build and immediately visible in delivered quality.

### Tier 2 — valuable but replicable

Photograph-a-question intake; session transcripts and whiteboards retained as revision assets; a sixty-second matching guarantee with automatic refund; repeat-tutor selection; declared tutor availability windows to make coverage predictable.

### Tier 3 — recommended against at this stage

Video, which doubles both build cost and safeguarding burden for marginal benefit; a proprietary AI answering capability, which competes directly with free substitutes and dilutes the human proposition; breadth of subject coverage beyond Maths and the three sciences; and scheduled bookings, where Sherpa and MyTutor hold a substantial lead.

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## 8. Regulatory considerations

The majority of intended users are under 18. This materially changes the obligations on the business.

**DBS checks.** Private one-to-one tutoring is not automatically classified as regulated activity under the Safeguarding Vulnerable Groups Act 2006, so enhanced checks are not universally mandated for self-employed tutors. However, the Act does require platforms to carry out enhanced DBS and barred-list checks on tutors working **unsupervised with under-18s**, which describes Project TA's service precisely. MyTutor, Tutorful and GoStudent all treat this as mandatory. Expect approximately **£40–60 and two to eight weeks per tutor**. *This is the principal reason the original proposal to admit "anyone" as a tutor cannot proceed.*

**ICO Age Appropriate Design Code.** A Data Protection Impact Assessment is **required** before launch, alongside data minimisation, high-privacy defaults, and age assurance proportionate to the assessed risk. The ICO updated its children's data guidance on **15 May 2026**.

**Online Safety Act 2023.** A service on which users message one another is a user-to-user service. Ofcom and the ICO issued a **joint statement on age assurance on 25 March 2026** setting common expectations for services likely to be accessed by children. Risk assessments, reporting and complaints mechanisms and content moderation are all required.

**Implications for the build.** An in-session reporting mechanism; retained and reviewable transcripts; automated blocking of contact-detail exchange; parent-account linkage with a lawful basis for processing a child's data; and a named, trained Designated Safeguarding Lead with a monitored inbox.

This should be treated as a build requirement rather than a compliance overhead. It represents roughly 20% of engineering effort and effectively all of the business's credibility with parents and schools.

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## 9. Unit economics

At £6 per fifteen-minute session, of which £4 is paid to the tutor:

| Line | Per session |
|---|---|
| Student pays | £6.00 |
| Tutor payment | (£4.00) |
| Card processing (approx. 1.5% + 20p) | (£0.29) |
| Payout fee, amortised | (£0.10) |
| **Contribution** | **approx. £1.61** |

A £2,000 monthly cost base therefore requires approximately **1,250 sessions per month**, or **42 per day**. This is attainable, but only with retention: a customer who purchases once will not repay an acquisition cost that, in UK edtech, typically runs to £15–40 per paying user.

**Three recommended mitigations, in order of impact.**

1. **Sell credit packs rather than single sessions.** £25 for five sessions, £45 for ten. This takes cash in advance and raises lifetime value. Snapask, Tutor.com and Skooli each converged on this structure. The single £6 session should be retained as a trial only.
2. **Make the parent the paying customer.** Under-18s rarely hold a payment card. A first-class parent account — parent funds the balance, student spends it, parent has transcript access — resolves the payment problem and a substantial part of the safeguarding problem simultaneously.
3. **Develop an institutional channel.** UPchieve at approximately £7,900 per school per year and Third Space Learning at £3,900–11,800 per school per year both demonstrate that schools will fund this service. A single school contract is equivalent to several hundred consumer sessions at a fraction of the support burden.

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## 10. Proposed launch plan

The marketplace cold-start problem, rather than the technology, is the principal execution risk.

**Weeks 1–4 — secure supply first, in one university and one subject.** Recruit 20–30 undergraduate maths and science tutors. **Pay a guaranteed hourly retainer for online availability** during a fixed evening window, 7pm to 10pm Sunday to Thursday, irrespective of session volume. This is a deliberate cost, incurred to purchase a matching-time guarantee.

**Weeks 3–8 — generate demand, narrowly.** Target one or two local secondary schools' parent groups and sixth forms. Time the launch to a revision peak: **the run-up to November mocks, and to summer examinations in April and May.**

**Measure two indicators only:** median time to match, and repeat purchase rate within fourteen days. If time to match exceeds three minutes, purchase additional supply. If repeat purchase falls below 25%, the product requires revision, and no marketing spend will compensate.

**Do not extend subject or geographic coverage until both indicators are healthy.**

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## 11. Risk register

| Risk | Severity | Mitigation |
|---|---|---|
| Free AI absorbs the quick-question use case | **High** | Position on comprehension rather than answers; exam-board specificity; human accountability |
| Tutor attrition at £16 per hour | **High** | Guaranteed availability payments at launch; fee transparency; prompt payment |
| Insufficient coverage outside peak hours | **High** | Fixed evening coverage windows; automatic refund if unmatched within 60 seconds |
| DBS cost and two-to-eight-week lead time constrain onboarding | Medium | Begin tutor recruitment before the product is complete; fund checks centrally |
| Safeguarding incident | **Critical** | Transcript retention, contact-detail blocking, in-session reporting, named DSL, completed DPIA |
| Disintermediation of the platform | Medium | Contact-detail blocking; repeat-tutor feature; a fair and published take rate |
| Chargebacks and disputes on low-value sessions | Medium | Credit rather than cash refunds; published complaints SLA; transcript as evidence |

## 12. Recommendation

It is recommended that the business proceed to a funded pilot on the model described, subject to **five changes** to the original proposal:

1. Tutors are to be **vetted undergraduates holding enhanced DBS checks**, not open registration.
2. **Parents are to be the paying customer** and are to have transcript access; students spend a balance.
3. **Credit packs are the commercial model**; the single £6 session is a trial mechanism, not the business.
4. Launch is to be confined to **Maths, Physics, Chemistry and Biology, at GCSE and A-level, routed by examination board**, in one city, within one evening coverage window.
5. **Safeguarding and fee transparency are to be the principal marketing positions**, being the two areas in which every identified incumbent is either weak or deliberately opaque.

The mechanic is proven. The failures in this category have overwhelmingly been failures of unit economics rather than of product. Securing the economics is the precondition; the technology is comparatively straightforward.

## Sources

UK market and competitors: Technavio and Research and Markets (UK K-12 online tutoring market 2026–2030); StudyGuru; TutorChase; Sherpa Online; MyTutor safeguarding and online-safety policies; TutorExtra UK platform DBS and fees report 2025; Third Space Learning pricing; Tracxn.

International comparators: Dealroom, CNBC, TechCrunch and Hive Life (Snapask); Wikipedia, SideHusl and Tracxn (Yup); MyEngineeringBuddy (UPchieve); ProProfs, Research.com and Wiingy (platform features and pricing); PrepMaven and Wiingy (Wyzant and Varsity Tutors); Lilach Bullock, Supatutor and Wealthvieu (tutor pay); Pertama Ventures (edtech funding and failure analysis); Entrepreneur (Chegg).

Regulatory: ICO Children's Code guidance and strategy; Covington Inside Privacy (Ofcom and ICO joint statement on age assurance, March 2026); Lewis Silkin (age assurance 2026); A&O Shearman (ICO children's information guidance update, May 2026); Tutes4u (UK online tutoring safeguarding and DBS guide 2026); Personnel Checks (tutoring safeguarding loophole).

Full URLs are retained in the project repository at `project-ta/docs/COMPETITOR-RESEARCH-SOURCES.md`.